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**SEMESTER:** AUTUMN 2025

**COURSE CODE: 4931**

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**Question 1: Describe the Pre-Islamic religious condition of the Arab.**

**Introduction**

The period in the Arabian Peninsula before the advent of Islam is known as the *Jahiliyyah*, commonly translated as the "Age of Ignorance." This term refers not to a lack of knowledge but to the absence of divine guidance. The religious landscape of pre-Islamic Arabia was diverse and complex, characterized predominantly by polytheism but also including communities of monotheists and followers of other faiths.

**Main Religious Conditions**

1. **Polytheism and Idolatry:** The most dominant religious practice was the worship of idols and multiple gods (polytheism). The Kaaba in Makkah, originally built by Prophet Ibrahim (Abraham) for the worship of one God, had been turned into a pantheon housing approximately 360 idols. Each tribe and even individual households had their own specific deities.
    - **Major Deities:** Among the most prominent gods and goddesses were Hubal (the chief deity of the Quraysh in Makkah), Al-Lat, Al-Uzza, and Manat, who were referred to as the "daughters of Allah."
    - **Rituals:** Rituals included animal sacrifices, pilgrimages to the Kaaba, and circumambulation (Tawaf), but these were directed towards the idols rather than the one true God.

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2. **Hanifism (Monotheism):** Amidst the widespread polytheism, there existed a small but significant minority known as the *Hanafā* (singular: *Hanif*). They rejected idolatry and adhered to the pure monotheistic faith of Prophet Ibrahim. They believed in a single, supreme God but were not formally affiliated with either Judaism or Christianity. Figures like Waraqah ibn Nawfal and Zayd ibn Amr were well-known *Hanafā*.
3. **Judaism:** Jewish communities had a strong presence in Arabia, particularly in the city of Yathrib (later Madinah) and in regions like Khaybar and Yemen. Major Jewish tribes in Yathrib, such as the Banu Qurayza, Banu Nadir, and Banu Qaynuqa, were influential in the city's economic and social life. They had their own synagogues, schools, and followed the teachings of the Torah.
4. **Christianity:** Christianity had also established a foothold in various parts of the peninsula. It was particularly prevalent among the tribes on the northern borders who were influenced by the Byzantine (Eastern Roman) Empire, such as the Ghassanids. In the south, the city of Najran was a major center of Christianity. Both Nestorian and Monophysite (Jacobite) Christian sects were present in Arabia.
5. **Other Beliefs and Superstitions:**
    - **Zoroastrianism:** The influence of the neighboring Persian Sassanian Empire brought Zoroastrianism to parts of eastern Arabia, although it was not widely practiced by the Arabs themselves.
    - **Animism and Superstitions:** Many Arabs believed in spirits (*jinns*), ghouls, and other supernatural beings that inhabited the desert. They heavily relied on soothsayers (*kahins*), divination (e.g., through casting arrows), and held numerous superstitions about omens and fortune-telling. There was a general lack of belief

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in a structured afterlife, resurrection, or divine accountability.

**Conclusion**

The religious condition of pre-Islamic Arabia was a mixture of decaying idolatry, ancestral traditions, and the presence of established monotheistic faiths like Judaism and Christianity. It was into this spiritually fragmented and morally ambiguous environment that Islam emerged, calling for a return to the pure monotheism of Ibrahim and establishing a comprehensive system of belief, law, and morality.

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**Question 2: Describe the important events of the life of the Holy Prophet (PBUH) at Makkah.**

**Introduction**

The Makkan period of the Prophet Muhammad's (PBUH) life, spanning from his birth in approximately 570 CE to his migration (Hijra) to Madinah in 622 CE, is foundational to Islam. This period is divided into two phases: his life before prophethood and his 13-year mission of preaching Islam amidst severe opposition in his hometown of Makkah.

**Key Events in Makkah**

1. **Birth and Early Life (c. 570-610 CE):**
    - Born in the "Year of the Elephant" into the Banu Hashim clan of the Quraysh tribe.
    - He was orphaned at a young age, losing his father Abdullah before birth, his mother Amina at age six, and his grandfather Abdul Muttalib at age eight.
    - He was raised by his loving uncle, Abu Talib, who was the chief of Banu Hashim.
    - In his youth, he earned the titles *Al-Sadiq* (the Truthful) and *Al-Amin* (the Trustworthy) for his impeccable character and honesty.
    - At the age of 25, he married the respected businesswoman,

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Khadijah (R.A), who was 40 at the time.

2. **The First Revelation (c. 610 CE):**
    - At the age of 40, during one of his retreats for meditation in the Cave of Hira on Jabal al-Nour (Mountain of Light), he received the first revelation. The Angel Jibril (Gabriel) appeared and commanded him to "Read!" (Iqra!). These were the first verses of Surah Al-Alaq, marking the beginning of his prophethood.
3. **The Phase of Preaching (610-622 CE):**
    - **Secret Preaching (3 years):** Initially, the Prophet (PBUH) preached secretly to his close family and friends. The first converts were his wife Khadijah, his cousin Ali ibn Abi Talib, his freed slave Zayd ibn Harithah, and his close friend Abu Bakr.
    - **Public Preaching:** After three years, he was commanded by Allah to preach openly. He declared his message on Mount Safa, inviting the Quraysh to monotheism, which was met with ridicule and hostility.
    - **Persecution:** As more people, especially the poor and enslaved, embraced Islam, the Quraysh leadership intensified their persecution. Converts like Bilal ibn Rabah and the family of Yasir faced brutal torture. Sumayyah bint Khabbat became the first martyr of Islam.
    - **Migration to Abyssinia (c. 615 CE):** To protect his followers from severe persecution, the Prophet (PBUH) permitted two groups of Muslims to migrate to Abyssinia (modern-day Ethiopia), which was ruled by a just Christian king, the Negus.
    - **The Social Boycott (c. 616-619 CE):** The Quraysh imposed a complete social and economic boycott on the clans of Banu Hashim and Banu Muttalib for protecting the Prophet. They were forced to live in a narrow valley (Shi'b Abi Talib) for three years,

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facing extreme hardship and starvation.

4. **The Year of Sorrow (c. 619 CE):**
    - Shortly after the boycott ended, the Prophet (PBUH) suffered two immense personal losses. His beloved wife and strongest supporter, Khadijah (R.A), and his uncle and protector, Abu Talib, both passed away. This year is known as *Aam al-Huzn* (The Year of Sorrow).
5. **Isra and Miraj (The Night Journey and Ascension):**
    - As a divine consolation after the Year of Sorrow, the Prophet (PBUH) was taken on a miraculous night journey from Makkah to Jerusalem (*Isra*) and then ascended to the heavens (*Miraj*). During this event, the five daily prayers (*Salah*) were prescribed.
6. **The Pledges of Aqabah and The Hijra (621-622 CE):**
    - Finding little success in Makkah, the Prophet (PBUH) began preaching to pilgrims from other tribes. He met a group from Yathrib (Madinah) who accepted Islam and pledged their allegiance to him at a place called Aqabah.
    - The following year, a larger delegation came and took the Second Pledge of Aqabah, inviting the Prophet (PBUH) to their city and promising to protect him.
    - Following a Quraysh plot to assassinate him, the Prophet (PBUH), by divine command, migrated to Madinah in 622 CE. This event, the *Hijra*, marks the beginning of the Islamic calendar and the start of a new phase for the Muslim community.

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**Question 3: (Answer to ONE part)**

**Part A: Who were the claimants of false prophethood in the era of Hazrat Abu Bakar Siddique (R.A)?**

**Introduction**

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Following the death of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH), the nascent Islamic state faced several grave challenges during the caliphate of Hazrat Abu Bakar (R.A). One of the most serious threats was the rise of several individuals who falsely claimed to be prophets. This led to the Ridda Wars (Wars of Apostasy), where Abu Bakar took decisive action to crush these rebellions and preserve the finality of prophethood in Islam.

**The Main Claimants of False Prophethood**

1. **Musaylimah al-Kadhdhab (The Liar):**
    - **Background:** Hailing from the powerful Banu Hanifa tribe in the region of Yamama, Musaylimah was the most dangerous of the false prophets. He had a massive following and a well-organized force.
    - **Claims:** He claimed that Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) had made him a partner in prophethood. He composed rhyming prose in an attempt to imitate the Quran and permitted his followers to drink wine and fornicate, thus relaxing religious laws to attract support.
    - **Defeat:** Abu Bakar dispatched an army under the command of the brilliant general Khalid ibn al-Walid. In the fierce Battle of Yamama (632 CE), the Muslim army defeated Musaylimah's forces. Musaylimah himself was killed by Wahshi ibn Harb, the same man who had killed Hamza (R.A) at Uhud.
2. **Tulayha ibn Khuwaylid al-Asadi:**
    - **Background:** Tulayha was a chief of the Banu Asad tribe. He had initially claimed prophethood during the Prophet's lifetime but had been suppressed.
    - **Rebellion:** After the Prophet's death, he apostatized again and rallied several tribes around him, challenging the authority of the caliphate.
    - **Defeat and Repentance:** Khalid ibn al-Walid's army marched

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against him and defeated his forces at the Battle of Buzakha. Unlike Musaylimah, Tulayha managed to escape. He later sincerely repented, returned to Islam, and proved his loyalty by fighting bravely for the Muslim army in the later conquests of Persia and Iraq.

3. **Sajah bint al-Harith:**
    - **Background:** Sajah was a woman from the Banu Tamim tribe who had a background in Christianity. She was a charismatic soothsayer who claimed to be a prophetess.
    - **Alliance and Decline:** She gathered a large following and initially planned to attack Madinah. However, she instead decided to join forces with Musaylimah. Reports suggest they married, and she accepted his prophetic "superiority." Her movement quickly collapsed after Musaylimah was defeated and killed. She later fled and eventually embraced Islam.
4. **Al-Aswad al-Ansi:**
    - **Background:** Known as "The Veiled Prophet" due to him covering his face, Al-Aswad was the leader of the Ansi tribe in Yemen.
    - **Rebellion:** He claimed prophethood during the final days of the Prophet Muhammad's (PBUH) life. He successfully led a rebellion, expelled the Muslim administrators, and captured the capital, Sana'a.
    - **Defeat:** His tyrannical rule was short-lived. He was assassinated by a group of Yemeni Muslims of Persian descent, led by Fayruz al-Daylami, just before the news of the Prophet's death reached Yemen. Abu Bakar's forces later had to quell the remaining unrest in the region.

**Conclusion**

The swift and resolute response of Caliph Abu Bakar (R.A) against the false

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prophets was crucial for the survival of Islam. His actions firmly established the core Islamic creed of the finality of Prophethood with Muhammad (PBUH) and ensured the political and religious unity of Arabia under the authority of the caliphate.

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**Part B (OR): Explain the reasons for the martyrdom of Hazrat Usman (R.A).**

**Introduction**

The martyrdom of the third Caliph, Hazrat Usman ibn Affan (R.A), in 656 CE was a tragic and pivotal event in Islamic history. It marked the beginning of the first *Fitna* (civil strife) within the Muslim community. His assassination was not the result of a single cause but a culmination of various political, social, and economic grievances that were skillfully exploited by agitators.

**Reasons for the Rebellion and Martyrdom**

1. **Allegations of Nepotism:**
    - Caliph Usman belonged to the powerful Banu Umayya clan. He appointed several of his relatives to prominent positions as governors, such as his cousin Mu'awiya in Syria, his foster brother Abdullah ibn Sa'd in Egypt, and his half-brother Walid ibn Uqba in Kufa.
    - While many of these appointees were competent administrators (e.g., Mu'awiya), this policy created widespread resentment. Critics felt that the caliph was favoring his own clan over more deserving early Companions and that the Umayyads were consolidating power.
2. **Economic Grievances:**
    - The era of rapid conquests had brought immense wealth into the Islamic state. Usman was accused of being too generous with the state treasury (*Bayt al-Mal*), granting large estates and sums of

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money to his relatives and other prominent figures.

- This was perceived as a departure from the strict, austere policies of his predecessors, particularly Umar (R.A). Soldiers and settlers in the garrison towns of Iraq and Egypt felt their stipends and share of the wealth were being unfairly managed.

3. **Standardization of the Qur'an:**
   - One of Usman's greatest achievements was the official compilation and standardization of the Quranic text to prevent disputes over different readings. He ordered all other variant copies (*masahif*) to be burned.
   - While this act was vital for preserving the Quran, his enemies twisted it into a propaganda tool. They falsely accused him of "burning the word of Allah" and altering the holy text, stirring up religious sentiment against him among the less-informed populace.
4. **Discontent in the Provinces:**
   - The provincial garrison towns of Kufa (Iraq), Basra (Iraq), and Fustat (Egypt) were hotbeds of dissent. These were new cities populated by soldiers and tribesmen who were far from the central authority in Madinah.
   - Charismatic agitators, including figures like the historically controversial Abdullah ibn Saba, fanned the flames of discontent, spreading seditious rumors and coordinating opposition against the caliph.
5. **The Caliph's Lenient Character:**
   - Hazrat Usman was known for his piety, humility, and extremely gentle and forbearing nature. He was reluctant to use force against his opponents, preferring dialogue and persuasion.
   - When rebel factions from Egypt, Kufa, and Basra marched on Madinah and laid siege to his house, he forbade his supporters,

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including prominent Companions like Hasan, Husayn, and Abdullah ibn al-Zubayr, from fighting back, stating he did not want to be the cause of Muslim bloodshed in the Prophet's city.

**Conclusion**

The martyrdom of Usman (R.A) was the result of a "perfect storm" of factors: genuine grievances over administrative policies, perception of favoritism, skillful propaganda by subversive elements, and the Caliph's own gentle disposition. Rebels broke into his home and murdered him while he was reciting the Quran, an act that plunged the Muslim Ummah into its first major civil war and left a deep and lasting scar on Islamic history.

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**Question 4: (Answer to ONE part)**

**Part A: What academic achievements did caliph Haroon Al-Rashid perform during his time?**

**Introduction**

The reign of the fifth Abbasid Caliph, Haroon Al-Rashid (786-809 CE), is often considered the zenith of the Islamic Golden Age. His court in Baghdad became the world's most magnificent center for arts, culture, and science. Haroon's personal interest and lavish patronage of scholars and intellectual pursuits were instrumental in fostering an environment of unparalleled academic achievement.

**Major Academic Achievements and Contributions**

1. **Foundation of the Bayt al-Hikmah (House of Wisdom):**
    - Haroon Al-Rashid established a grand palace library, which was the precursor to the famous *Bayt al-Hikmah*. He began the process of collecting manuscripts from across the known world, particularly from Byzantine, Persian, and Indian civilizations. This collection formed the nucleus of the great academy that would be formally established and expanded by his son, Al-Ma'mun.
2. **The Translation Movement:**

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- Perhaps his most significant contribution was initiating and funding a massive and systematic translation movement. He sponsored scholars to translate major works of Greek, Persian, Syriac, and Sanskrit origin into Arabic.
- Works of philosophy (Plato, Aristotle), medicine (Galen, Hippocrates), mathematics (Euclid), and astronomy (Ptolemy) were translated, preserving this ancient knowledge for humanity and making it accessible to Arab and Muslim scholars for further development.

3. **Patronage of Scholars and Intellectuals:**
   - Haroon Al-Rashid's court was a magnet for the brightest minds of the era. He generously sponsored scholars, poets, musicians, scientists, and physicians, regardless of their faith or ethnic background.
   - His powerful viziers, the Barmakid family, were also great patrons of learning, further enhancing Baghdad's reputation as a global intellectual hub.
4. **Establishment of Educational and Scientific Institutions:**
   - During his reign, Baghdad saw the establishment of numerous libraries and academies. He also founded the first major hospital (*bimaristan*) in Baghdad, which served not only as a treatment center but also as a medical school where students could receive clinical training. This model of the teaching hospital was a major innovation.
   - He also encouraged the building of observatories for the study of astronomy, a field in which Muslim scholars would soon excel.
5. **Advancements in Science and Technology:**
   - The intellectual ferment of his time led to significant progress. His reign saw the early development of fields that would later flourish,

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such as algebra, chemistry, and optics.

- The level of technology was demonstrated by the famous water clock (a type of clepsydra) that Haroon sent as a diplomatic gift to Emperor Charlemagne of the Holy Roman Empire. The intricate mechanical device, which struck the hours and featured automated figures, astonished the European court.

**Conclusion**

Haroon Al-Rashid was not just a powerful political ruler but also a visionary patron of knowledge. By fostering the Translation Movement, establishing the foundations of the House of Wisdom, and creating a culture that valued learning and inquiry, he laid the essential groundwork for the scientific and cultural flourishing that defined the Islamic Golden Age. His reign transformed Baghdad into a beacon of knowledge that illuminated the world for centuries.

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**Part B (OR): Review the services of Sultan Salah-ud-Deen Ayyubi.**

**Introduction**

Sultan Salah-ud-Deen Ayyubi (known in the West as Saladin) (1137-1193 CE) is one of the most revered figures in Islamic history. As the founder of the Ayyubid dynasty, his life was dedicated to the service of Islam. His legacy is defined by three monumental achievements: the unification of Muslim forces, the liberation of Jerusalem from Crusader rule, and his exemplary character of justice, piety, and chivalry.

**Major Services of Salah-ud-Deen Ayyubi**

1. **Unification of Muslim Lands:**
   - When Salah-ud-Deen came to power, the Muslim world was politically fragmented and weak, which had allowed the First Crusade to succeed. His first great service was to unite the disparate Muslim principalities of Egypt, Syria, and Mesopotamia.
   - In 1171, he abolished the Shia Fatimid Caliphate in Egypt,

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restoring the region to Sunni orthodoxy and bringing its vast resources under his control. He then patiently and skillfully, through both diplomacy and military campaigns, unified Syria and parts of Iraq, creating a powerful and united front against the Crusader states.

2. **Liberation of Jerusalem and the Holy Land:**
    - This is his most celebrated service. After unifying the Muslims, he launched a major campaign against the Crusader Kingdom of Jerusalem.
    - **Battle of Hattin (1187):** He inflicted a catastrophic and decisive defeat upon the combined Crusader armies at the Battle of Hattin, capturing their king and many of their most important knights.
    - **Conquest of Jerusalem (1187):** Following the victory at Hattin, the path to Jerusalem was open. He conquered the city after a brief siege. His entry into Jerusalem after 88 years of Crusader occupation was a moment of immense triumph for the Muslim world.
3. **Chivalry and Just Conduct:**
    - Salah-ud-Deen's conduct during his conquests set a new standard for chivalry. In stark contrast to the brutal massacre of Muslims and Jews by the Crusaders in 1099, he treated the defeated Christians of Jerusalem with mercy and magnanimity.
    - He forbade any killing or plunder, allowed Christian inhabitants to ransom their freedom for a small sum, and even used his own money to pay the ransom for thousands of the poor who could not afford it. He guaranteed safe passage for those who left and allowed Christian pilgrims to continue visiting their holy sites. This earned him immense respect, even from his enemies.
4. **Defense against the Third Crusade:**

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- The fall of Jerusalem prompted Europe to launch the Third Crusade, led by Europe's most powerful monarchs, including Richard the Lionheart of England. Salah-ud-Deen successfully defended his gains against this formidable force.
- Although the Crusaders managed to capture the coastal city of Acre after a long siege, Salah-ud-Deen's strategic brilliance and the resilience of his army prevented them from retaking Jerusalem.

5. **Patron of Infrastructure and Learning:**
   - Beyond his military achievements, Salah-ud-Deen was a pious ruler who worked to strengthen the institutions of his empire. He was a great patron of education, founding numerous *madrasas* (colleges), mosques, and hospitals throughout his domain to promote Sunni Islamic learning and scholarship.

**Conclusion**

Salah-ud-Deen Ayyubi's services to Islam were immense. He revived the spirit of *jihad* in its truest sense—as a struggle for justice and the defense of the faith. By uniting the Muslims, liberating Jerusalem, and ruling with justice and compassion, he became an enduring symbol of ideal Islamic leadership and a hero not just for Muslims, but for all who admire courage, integrity, and chivalry.

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**Question 5: (Answer to ONE part)**

**Part A: Examine the leadership of different dynasties over Iran.**

**Introduction**

Iran, with its ancient and rich history, has been ruled by numerous dynasties since the advent of Islam. The leadership styles of these dynasties have profoundly shaped Iran's political, cultural, and religious identity. An examination of key dynasties like the Samanids, Seljuks, Safavids, and Qajars reveals a dynamic interplay of Persian culture, Islamic faith, and Turkic military

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power, culminating in the formation of modern Iran.

**Leadership of Key Dynasties**

1. **The Samanids (819–999 CE):**
    - **Leadership Style:** The Samanids, a Persian dynasty, are remembered for their cultural and administrative leadership rather than military expansion. They ruled from Bukhara and fostered a renaissance of Persian culture and language within an Islamic context.
    - **Impact:** Their courts became great centers of learning. They patronized literary giants like Rudaki, the "father of Persian poetry," and Ferdowsi, who began writing the epic *Shahnameh*. Their leadership successfully created a synthesis of Persian identity and Sunni Islam, laying the foundation for the Persian literary tradition that would flourish for centuries.
2. **The Seljuks (1037–1194 CE):**
    - **Leadership Style:** The Seljuks were a Turkic dynasty whose leadership was primarily military and political. After conquering Iran, leaders like Tughril Beg, Alp Arslan, and Malik-Shah established a vast empire. Their rule was characterized by a Turco-Persian symbiosis: Turkic military leaders governed, while Persian bureaucrats administered the state.
    - **Impact:** As staunch Sunnis, they championed orthodoxy against the Shia Fatimids. Their great vizier, Nizam al-Mulk, was a brilliant administrator who established the famous *Nizamiyya* madrasas (colleges) across the empire to promote Sunni education and train officials. Seljuk leadership reinforced Sunni Islam in Iran and established a model of governance that combined military might with sophisticated Persian administration.

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3. **The Safavids (1501–1736 CE):**
    - **Leadership Style:** The Safavid dynasty's leadership was transformative and theocratic. Its founder, Shah Ismail I, was a charismatic religious leader who declared Twelver Shi'ism the official state religion. He and his successors ruled as absolute monarchs with divine authority.
    - **Impact:** This policy was the single most important event in shaping modern Iranian identity. By forcibly converting the majority-Sunni population, the Safavids created a distinct Shia state, setting Iran apart from its powerful Sunni neighbors, the Ottoman Empire and the Mughals. Under leaders like Shah Abbas the Great, the Safavids centralized the state, modernized the army, and presided over a golden age of Persian art and architecture, with Isfahan as their magnificent capital.
4. **The Qajars (1789–1925 CE):**
    - **Leadership Style:** The leadership of the Qajar dynasty is largely seen as a period of decline. Their rule was marked by an inability to centralize power effectively and a failure to modernize in the face of growing European imperial pressure. Corruption was rampant, and the shahs often sold economic concessions to foreign powers (Britain and Russia) to fund their extravagant lifestyles.
    - **Impact:** Iran lost significant territory to Russia in the north and came under heavy British influence in the south. The weakness and mismanagement of Qajar leadership sparked popular discontent and led to major events like the Tobacco Protest (1891) and the Constitutional Revolution (1905–1911), which challenged the absolute power of the monarchy and laid the groundwork for modern Iranian politics.

**Conclusion**

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The leadership of different dynasties over Iran has left a complex legacy. The Samanids revived Persian culture, the Seljuks established a Turco-Persian state model, the Safavids forged a unique Shia identity, and the failures of the Qajars ignited the desire for modern reform. Each dynasty, through its unique leadership style, contributed crucial elements to the political and cultural tapestry of Iran.

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**Part B (OR): Review the main Muslim countries in Europe.**

**Introduction**

The presence of Islam in Europe has a long and rich history, dating back to the 8th century. This history is primarily defined by three major centers of Islamic civilization: Al-Andalus (in the Iberian Peninsula), the Emirate of Sicily, and the vast territories of the Ottoman Empire in the Balkans. These historical states have left an indelible cultural, architectural, and demographic legacy, including the modern-day Muslim-majority nations in Europe.

**Main Historical Muslim States in Europe**

1. **Al-Andalus (Islamic Spain, 711–1492):**
    - For nearly 800 years, large parts of the Iberian Peninsula (modern Spain and Portugal) were under Muslim rule. This period was a golden age of civilization in Europe.
    - **The Caliphate of Córdoba:** At its peak under the Umayyad Caliphate of Córdoba (929-1031), its capital, Córdoba, was the largest and most advanced city in Europe. It was a global center for science, medicine, philosophy, and art. Scholars like Ibn Rushd (Averroes) and Maimonides (a Jewish philosopher) thrived in its tolerant intellectual environment.
    - **Legacy:** Al-Andalus left a profound legacy in European culture, introducing new agricultural techniques, scientific knowledge (including Arabic numerals and algebra), and stunning

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architectural wonders like the Great Mosque of Córdoba and the Alhambra Palace in Granada.

2. **The Emirate of Sicily (831–1091):**
    - Muslims ruled Sicily for over two centuries, transforming the island into a prosperous and multicultural hub. The capital, Palermo, became a major Mediterranean metropolis.
    - **Legacy:** The Arabs introduced new crops like oranges, lemons, and sugarcane, along with advanced irrigation systems. Even after the Norman conquest of the island, the Arab-Islamic influence remained strong for centuries, evident in Sicilian art, architecture (the Arab-Norman style), and even the local language.
3. **The Ottoman Empire in the Balkans (c. 14th – early 20th century):**
    - The Ottoman Empire's rule over Southeastern Europe (the Balkans) was the most extensive and lasting Muslim presence on the continent, spanning over 500 years.
    - **Territories:** The Ottomans governed territories that include modern-day Bosnia and Herzegovina, Albania, Kosovo, Greece, Bulgaria, Romania, Serbia, and more.
    - **Legacy:** This long period of rule resulted in significant parts of the local population converting to Islam, particularly in Albania, Bosnia, and Kosovo. The Ottomans left a vast architectural heritage of mosques, bridges (like the Stari Most in Mostar), caravanserais, and bathhouses. Their influence is also seen in the region's cuisine, music, and vocabulary.

**Modern Muslim-Majority Countries in Europe**

The legacy of the Ottoman Empire is directly visible in the demographic makeup of modern Europe. The main Muslim-majority countries located entirely within Europe are:

- **Albania:** Over 58% of the population is Muslim.

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- **Kosovo:** Over 95% of the population is Muslim.
- **Bosnia and Herzegovina:** Muslims (known as Bosniaks) constitute the largest single group, at around 51% of the population.

Additionally, **Turkey**, which straddles Europe and Asia, is an overwhelmingly Muslim-majority country with a significant presence and historical role in European affairs.

**Conclusion**

From the glittering courts of Córdoba to the multicultural cities of the Ottoman Balkans, Muslim civilizations have been an integral part of European history. These historical "countries" or states were not peripheral but were major centers of power, learning, and culture that deeply influenced the course of European development. Their legacy continues today through their rich cultural heritage and the presence of vibrant Muslim communities and nations across the continent.

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